KU LEUVEN

DIGITAL SOCIETY INSTITUTE



ANNUAL REPORT

KU LEUVEN DIGITAL SOCIETY INSTITUTE

2023 –2024

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Introduction

What began in 2018 as a vision to unite KU Leuven scholars from diverse disciplines to positively contribute to a digital society, became a recognized initiative on May 1, 2021. As we approach our fourth year, it is time to reflect on our activities and set priorities for the future. The DigiSoc collective has grown stronger, with both new and reinforced collaborations around digital themes.

In the past, scholars from the same institution sometimes met at international conferences where they expressed an interest to collaborate. Yet they often lacked a context that could nurture these intentions from home soil. Our institute does not depend on distant chance encounters. In contrast, from within, it proactively creates accessible, welcoming and sustained opportunities for networking and engaging in thought-provoking, inspiring discussions and collaborations. In this annual report, you will read more about the activities of DigiSoc in the period of May 2023- April 2024. Our ambitions have already yielded tangible results, such as joint disseminations, projects, and training programmes. We also believe in the long-term benefits of DigiSoc fostering new generations of open-minded, collaborative scholars who find their way both within and across disciplinary contexts.

Our efforts to build bridges within KU Leuven have also had positive effects on the broader community. DigiSoc continues to create forums where academia and society intersect. Initially focused on local regions, our orientation has gradually expanded internationally. Balancing this global perspective with local sensitivity remains a key ambition.

In the coming years, we will carefully choose our stakeholders, in line with our clear goal: DigiSoc aims to be a key reference in key matters related to the digital society. We approach digital advancements thoughtfully, ensuring that their benefits are valuable to a wide range of people, communities, society, and the planet.

We invite you to join us in this mission. Maybe you would like to attend our next edition of the hybrid Digital Ethics course to concretize plans to contribute to positive digital transformations in your own life? Or you might have ideas of how we can collaborate in a project, tailored to the needs of your organisation, institute or company and in line with the DigiSoc values pursuing responsible, ethical and sustainable (use of) technologies? Or why not share your refreshing ideas and compelling insights at our International Conference for an Inclusive Digital Society (IDS2025) on September 15-16, 2025, in Leuven, Belgium? Hope to see and speak to you soon.

Prof. Dr. Bieke Zaman
Director
18 July 2024

DigiSoc in a Nutshell

The KU Leuven Digital Society Institute (DigiSoc) was launched in May 2021. This annual report is written at the end of its third year of operation and in transition to its fourth year of existence.

At the end of June 2024, DigiSoc has **143 members**, (+12 compared to previous year) of which 75 pay a membership fee and are part of the DigiSoc General Assembly. They include professors and their teams **from all three KU Leuven Science Groups**: Science, Engineering and Technology (SET); Humanities and Social Sciences (HSS); and Biomedical Sciences (BIOMED). Together, the members of DigiSoc represent more than 20 faculties and departments of our university.

The rest of this section provides an overview of DigiSoc's mission, research lines, working groups and governance model. **If you are already familiar with DigiSoc, you can skip this section.**

The mission of DigiSoc is to define a solid path towards a **positive digital future** by understanding, designing, developing, and critically reflecting on (new) interactions between people and digitally driven technology. DigiSoc aims to support and encourage excellent research and education as well as create impact on real-life applications and for diverse stakeholder groups. Its envisioned outcome is an **inclusive digital society** based on responsible, ethical, and sustainable (use of) technologies.

Through **four research lines**, we actively put this mission into practice by:

1. Understanding the effects of digitalisation on individuals and organisations.
2. Developing responsible, ethical, and sustainable digital technologies.
3. Designing new interactions with digital technology based on a value-centred approach.
4. Critically reflecting on and engaging with societal changes in a digital world.

As these research lines are closely intertwined and sometimes overlap, interactions between researchers working on each of these research lines is necessary to address domain-related challenges in an interdisciplinary way. Our activities are therefore carried out by **eight working groups** structured according to five thematic domains and three transversal programmes in order to foster true interdisciplinary collaboration:

1. Health and Wellbeing
2. Learning and Education
3. Media and Culture
4. Democracy and Civic Engagement
5. Work and Organisation
6. Technological and Societal Trends
7. Methodology
8. Digital Ethics (new – see section Key Activities)

Each of these working groups functions autonomously and is part of one of three task forces: a Domains Task Force, a Transversal Task Force and a Methodology Task Force. Figure 1 presents the governance model with the central role for the three task forces in interaction with the Executive Committee, represented by the brown central circles. The dynamic working groups are clustered with the relevant task force and represented with leaf-shaped notes, also suggesting the possible emergence of new working groups in the future. Figure 1 further shows that DigiSoc seeks alignment both within KU Leuven through interaction with an Internal Advisory Board, and outside KU Leuven through interaction with an External Advisory Board. The composition of the latter is characterised by representatives of government, industry, academia, and civil society. The advisory boards are consulted to obtain input to help shape future activities as well as to look back on already delivered activities and achievements.

All working group (co-)chairs are part of the Steering Committee, and report to the (co-)directors that head the respective task forces. The (co-)directors and research manager, who liaises with the External Advisory Board, form the Executive Committee. Paying members of DigiSoc are part of the General Assembly.

The governance model is based on five principles:

1. The governance model reflects DigiSoc's key objectives.
2. Dynamic working groups are given an executive role while the Executive Committee keeps the system together to achieve the shared mission.
3. The governance model builds on shared leadership within the consortium of top performers based on trust and autonomy.
4. It is flexible; working groups can easily be created in response to bottom-up initiatives and societal demands as well as disbanded when no longer meaningful for the mission or when inefficient.
5. It provides just enough structure: the structure will and must change if it is supporting too little or if it is too much of a burden.

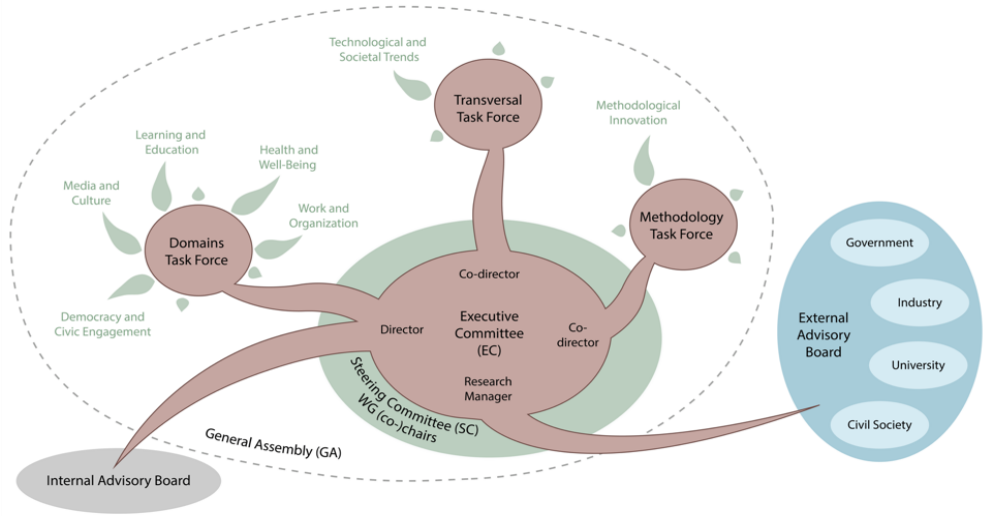


Figure 1: DigiSoc's Governance Model

Putting Recommendations in Practice

EAB RECOMMENDATIONS

DigiSoc has an External Advisory Board (EAB) that gathers once a year. The DigiSoc EAB is chaired by Isabelle François (Health House), and its members are Françoise Chombar (Melexis), Martijn Cielen (Cronos Group), Wim Dries (Stad Genk), Matthew Fuller (Goldsmiths, University of London, UK), Daniel Leufer (Access Now), Frank Liu (National Sun Yat-Sen University, TW), Keymanthri Moodley (Stellenbosch University, ZA), Frank Stumpe (KBC), and Dewi Van de Vyver (EFFEX).

On **6 September 2023**, the EAB met for the second time during an online meeting, where the EC presented DigiSoc's activities during the past operational year. After that meeting, the EAB wrote a report with recommendations, which DigiSoc has addressed in its past operational year as follows (more details on each of the activities can be found further in this annual report):

A first set of recommendations of the EAB meeting focused on **how to work towards financial independence**:

1. Increase of member fee.
    - The EAB's suggestion to increase the member fee was also suggested by KU Leuven. DigiSoc considered this but decided to keep membership fees as low as possible to be inclusive.
    - However, in the past year, DigiSoc has set up an optional fund for members to contribute to a **"sustainability fund"** to generate some more income. This has already been used once, and some of our members have expressed interest. The sustainability fund will be promoted each year in order to remain visible to our members.
2. The Digital Ethics Course could be developed as MA course with official accreditation.
    - The ambition to build an established curriculum around digital ethics with international flavour led to the **Erasmus+ proposal INTEGRITAS**, submitted in May 2023, and resubmitted in April 2024. The first and second proposal were not accepted but received promising reviews, therefore it is likely that we submit a third time. When accepted, this will give us the resources to develop the Digital Ethics course as MA course with official accreditation.
3. The expertise of DigiSoc could be turned into a service where DigiSoc could be a partner in projects covering ethical or societal aspects.
    - In **several project proposals**, DigiSoc has added a Work Package or tasks related to ethical or societal aspects. However, so far these have not yet been approved.

- We have applied for funding in a **Digital Inclusion call from the Federal Public Services Economy (FOD Economie)** to set up a counter for SMEs with DigiSoc, offering services to help them create more inclusive and accessible digital services. In October 2024 we will know whether it is accepted, and can start on 1 January 2025.
- Several **bilateral discussions are taking place** with stakeholders in and outside academia that should result in DigiSoc services tailored to their needs.

4. It was suggested to think about asking companies for a financial contribution.
    - As part of the celebrations for 600 Years of KU Leuven, the university's Fundraising office is aiming to arrange an **endowed chair** for each of the KU Leuven Institutes. Such an endowed chair would bring €75.000/year for 4 years to DigiSoc, i.e. €300.000. The Fundraising office is supporting us in getting in touch with potential donors.
    - On DigiSoc's website there is now a **donation button**, leading to a specific page where organisations or individuals can support DigiSoc financially.
5. It would be useful to evaluate how to even more improve the success rates for grant applications.
    - DigiSoc's outgoing research manager Dr. David Geerts has attended **several info-sessions** on writing successful grant applications, and has involved **KU Leuven's LRD and DOC departments** for support when applying for European grants.
6. Explore the submission of smaller-scale grants to build capability and capacity.
    - We have submitted proposals for several smaller-scale grants such as the **Digital Inclusion call from the Federal Public Services Economy (FOD Economie)**, and two **INTERREG** calls. We also aim for seed funding: we have been partner in a submission to UNA Europa Seed Funding, and are working towards a FWO Scientific Research Network submission.
7. Create visibility and awareness on the different services DigiSoc offers.
    - We have communicated to DigiSoc members about new services that DigiSoc offers (consultancy, project management, dissemination, and supervision of ethical or societal aspects of projects) mainly through the **promotion of the sustainability fund**. We will regularly repeat this communication, so our members remain aware of the opportunities.

In addition to the recommendations related to generating more income for DigiSoc, **various other recommendations** were made:

8. Think about the role DigiSoc can play when it comes to new technologies such as OpenAI's ChatGPT.
    - DigiSoc has participated in **several events** where it highlighted opportunities and challenges related to the ethical use of generative AI.

- DigiSoc is co-organizer of an international, hybrid event on the ethical dimensions of AI on October 1st 2024, please see https://www.aimforthefutureconference.com/.
- In collaboration with University of Tilburg, the **INTERREG project proposal "INNOVAITE"** has been submitted with the goal of supporting organisations to innovate more responsibly with Artificial Intelligence.

9. DigiSoc was invited to give a statement about societal relevance and digital inclusion to be added to the memorandum of the STEM platform that is now being drafted for next year's elections.
   - This suggestion has not been followed up, but if still relevant might come on the radar again.
10. Suggestion to connect with The House of AI, financed by Voorsprongfonds (an experience centre to learn about AI in different kinds of sectors).
    - This suggestion has not yet been followed up.
11. DigiSoc could play a role in the societal debate on the importance of health data (e.g. through collaboration with the European Health Data Spaces or Findata).
    - DigiSoc member Frank Rademakers (Chair WG Health & Well-Being) is working on creating a **workflow for the use of health data** and other sensitive personal data within KU Leuven, with the support of other DigiSoc members.
12. DigiSoc could link with different initiatives on learning such as the Expertisecentrum voor Effectief leren, Leerpunt Vlaanderen, EdTech Station at KULAK, or Waag Futurelab.
    - DigiSoc's research manager has had **informal contacts with several of these organisations**, but systematic collaborations have not yet been explored.
13. It was suggested to organise an event on climate change and its relation with technology.
    - On 1 October 2024, DigiSoc in collaboration with the Institute for Media Studies, organizes the **hybrid event "Ai(m) for the future"** in New York which will focus on the impact of AI on climate change, as well as on employment.
    - We will also organize a **design hackathon** with students on 11 December 2024, and hybrid **follow-up workshops** in Leuven in May 2025, with the same themes.
14. The internationalisation plans of DigiSoc start in Europe, but will already plant seeds globally. During the EAB meeting, DigiSoc welcomed contacts on the African continent.
    - Initiated by EAB member Keymanthri Moodley, and supported by DigiSoc research manager, DigiSoc members Isabelle Huys, Ine Van Hoyweghen and Pascal Borry have had a meeting with Stuart Rennie to **discuss possible collaborations as part of their NIH**



funded project on Big Data and AI, which as the intention to form a network linked to data ethics and AI.

- In collaboration with game designer and scholar **Celia Hodent** (US), who runs the Ethical Games Conference, and the **Fairplay Alliance**, a US-based, international organization, DigiSoc will be the scientific partner contributing to the establishment of a transdisciplinary Code of Conduct for game design professionals.
- In parallel with the latter mission, DigiSoc will lead an application for the **FWO Scientific Research Network** around the concept of Inclusive Perspectives on Ethical Game Design. This seed project aims to gather researchers from all continents in hybrid workshops, as well as experts from outside academia (including Celia and Fairplay Alliance) with the aim of developing more large-scale projects in the near future.

Key Activities

In its third operational year, from **May 2023 to May 2024**, DigiSoc's research manager has focused on organizing a couple of key activities, with the support of many DigiSoc members.

SUSTAINABILITY FUND

In December 2023, DigiSoc launched a **Sustainability Fund**. The goal of this fund is to enable new research or educational activities aligned with the mission of DigiSoc, supported by funding from DigiSoc members. The larger aim is to contribute to building a sustainable income for DigiSoc.

If DigiSoc members have funding available, e.g. as part of a project that is in line with DigiSoc's mission, the DigiSoc Executive Committee can help them to consider how DigiSoc can use this funding to support the activities. Examples include (but are not limited to):

- Co-organizing the closing event of a project
- Disseminating (part of) the project results, e.g. through a podcast, blog, event or other communication tools
- Inviting a research fellow to study a particular research topic that has not been addressed yet
- Exploring new project funding opportunities
- ...

These activities will be clearly linked with the project the funds are coming from, so they are eligible costs within the project. If the funds come from a more general source, the name or research group of the DigiSoc member involved can be linked to the activity, should they wish so.

While there was some initial interest in the sustainability fund, thus far only one group of DigiSoc members have made use of it. We will regularly communicate this fund to our DigiSoc members, and stimulate to make use of it.

DIGISOC ON TOUR

As part of our plans to connect with other Digital Society institutes and initiatives in Europe and beyond, we have started to visit a couple of universities in the Netherlands, our closest neighbours.

On the morning of Monday 2 October 2023, we visited prof. Sally Waytt at **Maastricht University**, and met with prof. Katleen Gabriëls and prof. Thomas Frissen, the programme directors of the interdisciplinary BA Digital Society.

In the afternoon, we exchanged experiences and discussed possible collaborations with prof. Boudewijn Haverkort and drs. Martin van der Broek, resp. academic lead and program manager of the Digital Sciences for Society program at **Tilburg University**.

One month later, on Monday 6 November 2023, we presented DigiSoc to a delegation from **Utrecht University** who visited KU Leuven.

We also welcome more **ad-hoc introductions** to similar institutes or initiatives. For instance, prof. Marco Gui reached out to us in April and July 2024. He is director of the Digital Transformation and Wellbeing Lab (DiTWeL) at the University of Milano-Bicocca in Italy. DiTWeL is an interdisciplinary research, innovation and training center that sets out to study the relationship between digital media use and quality of life, and design solutions to improve it. We also were introduced to Dr. Florence Chee in March 2024. She is the Director of the Center for Digital Ethics and Policy at Loyola University in Chicago. She also leads an annual symposium bringing together scholars across several disciplines to discuss ethical concerns with respect to current trends in screen use.

PREPARATION EVENTS 600 YEARS KU LEUVEN

As part of the celebrations surrounding 600 years of KU Leuven in 2025, we will organize several events that aim to position DigiSoc more firmly as reference and key player, nationally and internationally. In our past operational year, we started the preparations for these events, the first one of which will already take place in October 2024.

AI(M) for the Future: Exploring the Ethical Dimensions of a Digital Society

As a first event, supported by the **Hoover Ethical Initiatives** (an initiative of Ethics@KU Leuven), we will organize "AI(M) for the Future: Exploring the Ethical Dimensions of a Digital Society," scheduled for October 1, 2024, at New York University (NYU). This event, organized by the Regional Committee North America, DigiSoc, and LUSI, will adopt a hybrid format, allowing both in-person and virtual participation.

The event will begin with a welcome and overview session, setting the stage for a panel discussion moderated by Bieke Zaman from DigiSoc. The panel will explore the intersections of AI, law, and ethics, featuring esteemed experts such as Frank Pasquale (human expertise in AI), Benedetta Brevini (AI's impact on climate), and Nathalie Smuha (regulatory perspectives from the EU and USA). This session aims to provide diverse perspectives on how AI is reshaping various facets of society. Following the morning discussions, attendees will have the opportunity to network and engage in conversations, fostering connections and further discussion on the topics covered.

The afternoon will feature four parallel guided city tours in Manhattan, each focusing on different themes related to AI, sustainability, and diversity. These tours will be followed by a debate on the societal impact of AI and an introduction to the NY HUB, moderated by Ben Derudder (LUSI) and Kris Scheerlinck (LUCA School of Arts), with participation from Eric Klinenberg from NYU's Institute for Public Knowledge. The day will conclude with a networking and closing reception for KU Leuven alumni, providing an introduction to KU Leuven's interdisciplinary institutes and fostering further connections with Flanders House.

Follow-up Workshops

In May 2025, a series of follow-up workshops will be held at KU Leuven to build on the discussions from the New York event. These workshops will delve deeper into AI's impact on employment, climate, and smart cities, with the goal of developing policy recommendations for ethical AI development.

- Focus on **AI and Human Employment**, led by Frank Pasquale (Cornell Tech) and Valeria Pulignano (KU Leuven), addressing the evolving job landscape, reskilling, upskilling, and equitable access to AI opportunities.
- **AI and Climate**, with experts Benedetta Brevini (NYU) and Katja Biedenkopf (KU Leuven), exploring AI-driven sustainability initiatives and ethical considerations in environmental conservation.
- **AI and Smart Cities**, a co-creative workshop with Ben Derudder (LUSI), Kris Scheerlinck (LUCA School of Arts), and Eric Klinenberg (NYU), focusing on optimizing resource allocation, enhancing sustainability, and improving public safety through AI.
- Policy Note Collaboration, where participants from institutions like Cornell Tech, NYU, and KU Leuven will create policy documents on AI's impact on climate, employment, and smart cities. These documents will be presented to policymakers at various levels.

The event will conclude with a summary of key takeaways and a discussion on next steps for disseminating the policy notes to relevant stakeholders. The workshops will be conducted in a hybrid format, ensuring accessibility and encouraging broad participation. Networking opportunities will be facilitated to promote collaboration and knowledge exchange, ultimately aiming to drive positive change through informed and ethical AI policies.

Design Hackathon

DigiSoc, in collaboration with the KU Leuven Master of Communication Sciences: Digital Media and Society program, will organize a design hackathon to address societal challenges through innovation. This event will include inspiring keynote speeches, sensitizing activities, and interactive exercises. Students will work in interdisciplinary groups to define problems, generate ideas, create rapid prototypes, and present their results. The hackathon will link with existing DigiSoc initiatives and guest lectures, and will culminate in a prize-giving ceremony. The outcomes will be showcased in the workshops mentioned above and our academic conference in Leuven (see next), ensuring continued dissemination through DigiSoc channels. The goal is to enable students from diverse backgrounds to contribute meaningfully and learn from each other. The hackathon will take place on 11 December 2024.

International Conference for an Inclusive Digital Society (IDS2025)

Finally, DigiSoc will host the International Conference for an Inclusive Digital Society (IDS2025), which will take place on **September 15-16, 2025**, in Leuven, Belgium. This event aims to explore how digital technologies shape and are shaped by society, addressing themes like health, education, media, democracy,

and work. The conference seeks to foster dialogue among scholars, industry professionals, and policymakers to promote an inclusive, ethical, and sustainable digital future.

IDS2025 invites scholars, industry professionals, government representatives, and non-profits to submit abstracts for presentations exploring the impact of digital technologies on DigiSoc related topics such as health & well-being, learning & education, media & culture, democracy & civic engagement, and work & organisation. Submissions should address the design, governance, and ethical implications of digital tools. Abstracts, limited to 1000 words, should align with the conference themes. The submission period is from December 1, 2024, to February 15, 2025.

For more details, visit: Inclusive Digital Society Conference 2025.

CALL FOR VISITING FELLOWS IN COLLABORATION WITH LECTIO

The LECTIO and DigiSoc Visiting Fellowship for the academic year 2024-2025 is a joint initiative between LECTIO and DigiSoc's Working Group Media and Culture. This non-stipendiary fellowship invites scholars to explore the reception of the past in the digital society, focusing on how historical texts, ideas, and images are represented or reconfigured using new technologies. The fellowship includes a 4-6 week research stay at KU Leuven, covering travel expenses up to 500€, accommodation, access to university facilities, and office space. Fellows are expected to reside in Leuven for the duration, engage with LECTIO and DigiSoc communities, present at least one open seminar, and acknowledge the fellowship in related publications. The application is open to researchers from postdoc on and requires a CV, a project description, and the name of an academic host from LECTIO or DigiSoc.

This year, the fellowship has been awarded to **Julien Régibeau** from Liège University for a project entitled "History as Aesthetic: Exploring the Reuse of Historical Imagery in the Creation and Reception of Video Games". Julien will be hosted by Bieke Zaman (DigiSoc), Violet Soen en Barbara Baert (both LECTIO).

NEW WORKING GROUP ON DIGITAL ETHICS

In our past operational year, we established a new Working Group (WG) on Digital Ethics, as this is a topic that permeates a lot of activities within DigiSoc, but wasn't addressed explicitly by one of the working groups yet. The WG Digital Ethics is chaired by DigiSoc members Dr. Patrick de Mazière and Dr. Priscilla Van Even, and held their first meeting on 13 June 2024.

One of the aims of this new working group is to capture and exchange state-of-the-art knowledge to ensure the Digital Ethics course remains current. Additionally, the WG will facilitate collaborative research projects and joint publications. It might also serve as an advisory board for third parties, a role that is still under discussion.

This WG will work closely with Ethics @KU Leuven, a more comprehensive working group on all things ethical at KU Leuven, and one of its primary tasks will be to clarify the landscape of various Ethics working groups at KU Leuven and related entities such as Leuven.AI, the Ethical Committee @UZ/KU Leuven, Ethics

@primary care KU Leuven, and the Vlaamse AI Academie (VAIA). This effort will help both internal and external stakeholders understand the appropriate points of contact for their needs.

The WG Digital Ethics will focus on the ethical aspects of existing and emerging technologies through three levels of analysis. First, at the meta level, it will develop a holistic reference framework, examining the capabilities and limitations of technology, its public interest, societal impact, and authoritative oversight. Second, it will scrutinize the processes prescribed by these technologies, questioning ethical design, risk tolerance, inclusivity, and accountability. Finally, it will consider the perspectives of stakeholders, including end-users and creators, addressing the mitigation of side effects, societal consequences, preconditions for use in education, research, and daily work, and ensuring inclusivity.

DIGISOC PODCAST

On 21 June 2024, we launched the second season of the DigiSoc podcast, in which (PhD) researchers from DigiSoc are interviewed by DigiSoc's research manager Dr. David Geerts about how their research contributes to a positive digital society. We released 8 episodes with 30-40 minute interviews each on various podcast platforms.



Figure 2: DigiSoc podcast on Spotify

The DigiSoc Podcast is an engaging way of showing how we promote our mission and make the research insights of DigiSoc's early career scholars from a wide range of disciplinary backgrounds visible to the wider public. The podcast is available to listen to on our website, on Spotify, and on Apple Podcasts.

The following episodes of the **second season** are available:

1. Decoding Brain Activity - Jingyuan Sun
2. Social Media and Health Risk Behaviour - Sofie Vranken and Robyn Vanherle
3. Wearables and VR in Healthcare - Bert Bonroy
4. AI and the Teacher' Role - Kristina Krushinskaia
5. Videogames and Gambling - Maarten Denoo
6. Diabetes Self-Management Platform - Genet Tadese Aboye
7. Employee participation in Industry 4.0 - Yennef Vereycken
8. AI and the Future of Work - Anastasia Siapka

The **first season** had a modest audience (see Figure 3), which we think can still grow through the second season being advertised. To this end, we are currently putting more effort in promoting the podcast on various channels, which seems to already bear fruit (with an increase of ca. 10% of the views since the launch of the new promotion campaign).

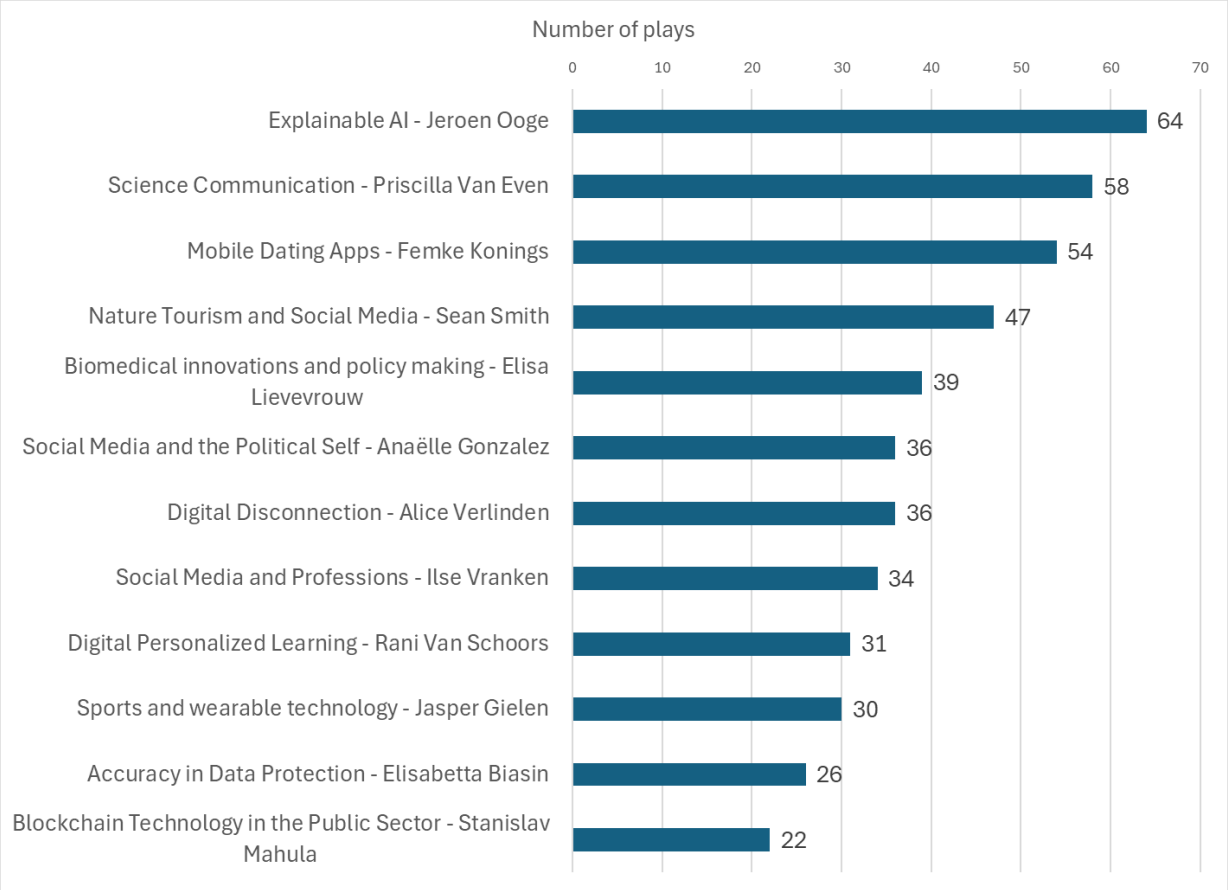


Figure 3: Episode titles, interviewees and number of plays of the DigiSoc Podcast Season 1 (status 19.07.2024).

HYBRID DIGITAL ETHICS COURSE

DigiSoc developed a course for training *Digital Ethicists* from scratch. This course, in which various DigiSoc members and external instructors teach one or more sessions, ran for the first time from May 2023 to June 2023 for 14 participants, who positively evaluated the course. The course covered a range of key topics in the realm of digital ethics, including ethics frameworks and tools, regulation and legal issues, ethical technology development and design, technology assessment, ethical dilemmas, and ethics in data and visualisation.

KEY ACTIVITIES

We organized the Digital Ethics course **for the second time** from mid-April to the end of June 2024. We expanded the programme with 2 extra sessions based on feedback from the previous edition. For this edition, 23 participants were registered. The course was evaluated very positively, which encourages us to continue the course in the next operational years. Additionally, some participants also expressed interest for follow-up workshops or training tailored to the needs and context of their company/organisation, which is something we will follow-up in the near future.

Project Procurement

During our third operational year (May 2023 – April 2024), we have submitted or were preparing 11 project proposals (see table below) that received support from DigiSoc's research manager, which is the same as last year.

The role of the research manager varied from being the main coordinator (n = 4), to WP lead (n = 2), key partner (n = 1), dissemination partner (n = 2), member of steering committee (n = 1), and partner (n = 1). See the column "DigiSoc Role" for the involvement of DigiSoc's research manager (RM) in bold. All projects involve a variety of partners from academia, industry and societal stakeholders.

Of these project proposals, 1 has been accepted, 5 have not been accepted, 1 was inadmissible, 2 are submitted and awaiting the results, and 2 are in progress and will be submitted from September 2024 onwards.

PROJECTS THAT ARE SUBMITTED OR IN PROGRESS

ACRONYM or TITLE	FUNDING SOURCE	STATUS	DIGISOC CONTRIBUTION
StressTRACS	**C3 KU Leuven Internal Funding**	**Accepted**	**Advisory Board Member (led by DigiSoc members M3-BIORES KU Leuven and Mobilab & Care Thomas More)**
LOOK-IT	**Digitale Inclusie (FOD Economie)**	**Submitted on 5/6/2024**	**Coordinator**
INTEGRITAS	**ERASMUS-EDU-2024-PI-ALL-INNO-EDU-ENTERP**	**Re-submitted on 7/3/2024, not accepted (score : 78/100)**	**Coordinator**
Carousel-Next	**HORIZON-EIC-2023-TRANSITIONOPEN-01**	**First two submissions not accepted, to be re-submitted on 14/9/2024**	**WP lead: Validation through Randomized Controlled Trials (Jannique Van Uffelen) / Task lead: Ethical and legal requirements**
PLAYWELL	**HORIZON-HLTH-2024-STAYHLTH-01-02-two-stage**	**First stage proposal not accepted**	**Coordinator**
Tech4Wellbeing	**COOK+ VLAIO**	**Submitted in the first stage, own decision to postpone final submission to next call**	**WP lead: Dissemination and Valorisation**

PROJECT PROCUREMENT

ACRONYM or TITLE	FUNDING SOURCE	STATUS	DIGISOC CONTRIBUTION
HARMONY	INTERREG NWE	First stage proposal not accepted *(plans to resubmit)*	Coordinating the dissemination activities
INNOVAITE	INTERREG Vlaanderen-Nederland	Inadmissible due to human error in portal during submission *(plans to resubmit)*	Key Partner
PARTiCIPARTE	HORIZON-CL2-2024-DEMOCRACY-01-08	Not accepted but put on the reserve list (score: 13/15)	Dissemination, Exploitation and Communication partner
AIHUM101	UNA Europa Seed Funding	Submitted on 28/6/2024	Partner
Inclusive Perspectives on Ethical Game Design	FWO Scientific Research Network	In progress, to be submitted on 2/9/2024	Coordinator

STRESSTRACS: STRESS TRACKING IN REAL LIFE WITH MULTIMODAL ALGORITHMS USING DATA FROM COMMERCIAL WEARABLES IN A STUDENT AND STAFF POPULATION

Related WGs: Health & Well-Being

Abstract: Over one in three Flemish residents own a wearable for continuous monitoring of behaviour and physiology. However, few widely available devices use scientifically validated algorithms to detect stress. This discourages companies to integrate this technology in current stress and mental health applications. Since stress is a complex and individual experience affecting both the autonomic nervous system and subjective experience, we hypothesise that combining datasets containing multimodal daily life data (physiological and self-assessment) with machine learning and datamining techniques will provide new scientific evidence for monitoring stress using commercial wearables. About 45% of Flemish students experiences regular to constant study strain and 20% has a mental health problem with a serious impact on daily life, so we will include students of the KU Leuven association. Additionally, we will include staff members to increase diversity and potential generalisation of the findings. The proposed research will allow companies to bring current mental health applications to a higher level by including a novel yet evidence-based data stream for stress identification.

Project partners: M3-BIORES KU Leuven and Mobilab & Care Thomas More

DigiSoc involvement: Advisory Board member

LOOK-IT: LOKET ONDERNEMINGEN VOOR KENNISGEBASEERDE INCLUSIEVE TECHNOLOGIE

Related WGs: Digital Ethics

Abstract: Our project focuses on supporting SMEs in designing user-friendly, accessible, and inclusive digital applications. We will set up a service desk that helps companies make their websites and apps more user-friendly according to the principles of human-centered and value-centered design. Through audits, training sessions, workshops, and consulting services, we ensure that SMEs are better equipped to optimize the usability of their digital channels and products, while also paying sufficient attention to alternative channels. Additionally, we ensure compliance with the European Accessibility Act and WCAG guidelines. Our goal is to reduce digital exclusion and create an inclusive customer experience. We collaborate with designers, developers, and users to promote co-creation and co-design. This initiative contributes to better digital accessibility and inclusivity in the business world.

Project partners: KU Leuven DigiSoc

DigiSoc involvement: Coordinator

INTEGRITAS: INNOVATIVE TRAINING OF ETHICISTS FOR GREATER RESPONSIBILITY IN TECHNOLOGY AND SOCIETY

Related WGs: Technological & Societal Trends

Abstract: Recently, technology companies and public sector organisations have started hiring digital ethicists to guide them towards a responsible use of technologies. The emergence of this new profession is a response to the increasing public pressure concerning the responsible use of technologies. Our preliminary needs analysis showed a clear market demand for digital ethicists, and a need to train people to assume these roles. The objectives and activities of this project are:

1. Developing a comprehensive, modular and multi-disciplinary curriculum for teaching digital ethics to students, professionals and public sector employees in higher education and vocational training on a postgraduate level.
2. Incorporating innovative practical, real-world examples and case studies into a digital ethics curriculum through interactive and experiential learning activities, that will better prepare students for a job as digital ethicist and support public sector employees procuring digital solutions.
3. Incorporating the needs from industry experts and organisations directly into VET and HE curricula by developing, testing and evaluating these curricula in close cooperation with these partners.
4. Equipping students, professionals and public sector employees with the knowledge and skills to make ethical decisions in their use of digital technologies, leading to more resilience for companies and organisations when new technologies arise, fostering corporate ethical and social responsibility, and enhancing Europe's innovation capacity.

The main outcome of the project is a modular, experience-based curriculum for professionals as well as for higher education students, that will enable Vocational Education & Training (VET) and Higher Education

(HE) providers to train the next generation of digital ethicists that can deal with the challenges of the new digital era, which will lead to more responsible and ethical use of digital technology and ultimately a more equitable and just society.

Project partners: KU Leuven, VUB, University of Utrecht, Maynooth University, University of Porto, Legal Beetle, Dublin City Council, Agoria, BeEthical

DigiSoc Involvement: Project coordinator

CAROUSEL-NEXT

Related WGs: Health & Well-Being; Media & Culture

Abstract: CAROUSEL-NEXT aims to develop and market a medical certified software service recommended for adults to improve mental and physical fitness. The service combines breakthrough AI technology with social dancing health benefits and is planned to be available anytime (24/7) from anywhere for its users. Our solution will allow remote users to interact with novel AI-Agents (intelligent social and physical virtual characters) as well as with each other in an online VR dancing world. Our innovation is the combination of AI and VR to create the feeling of immersion in an online social dancing crowd. The health benefits of this new social dancing service will be scientifically validated with Randomized Controlled Trials (RCT). A business plan for commercialization addressing the health tech market will be developed. Finally, the new service will be registered as a Medical Device Class 1 (MDC1).

Project partners: Deutsches Forschungszentrum für Künstliche Intelligenz, Grassroots Arts, VIVITnet, KU Leuven

DigiSoc Involvement: WP lead: Validation through Randomized Controlled Trials (Prof. Jannique Van Uffelen) / Task lead: Ethical and legal requirements

PLAYWELL: PLATFORM FOR LIFESTYLE ADJUSTMENT AND YOUTH WELL-BEING

Related WGs: Health & Well-Being

Abstract: The PLAYWELL project proposes a holistic and personalised strategy aimed at empowering children, adolescents, and their formal and informal carers in their physical, social, and mental health skills, with a particular focus on children and adolescents with intellectual disabilities (ID). To this end, we plan to develop a versatile digital platform, integrating serious games, a website, VR environments for health strategy experimentation, AR activities, and activity trackers (using wearables) that encourage social interaction and physical activity. This platform will not only allow for digital engagement but will also provide a mechanism for their formal and informal carers (parents, coaches, caregivers, …) to monitor progress and coach and motivate them in obtaining and maintaining a healthier lifestyle. Importantly, we also propose non-digital or mixed initiatives such as school-based workshops, classroom discussions, cooperative board games and playful physical assignments to complement our digital solutions, as we recognize the value of offline interactions in promoting a healthy lifestyle and social inclusion, aim at

reducing digital inequalities for vulnerable children and adolescents related to access, attitudes and skills, and want to support a positive and healthy relationship with technology embedded in sound interpersonal relationships. The project will produce guidelines and educational toolkits for social and healthy behaviour, accessible via our platform, to further educate and empower children and adolescents in their pursuit of health and well-being.

Recognizing that the children and adolescents with ID often exhibit higher risks of physical and mental health related problems, as well as their parents, and are often excluded from the design of such applications, our proposal utilises a "Design for All" approach by including children and adolescents from various backgrounds and conditions from the outset. Our interventions will address the challenges of low health literacy and social isolation prevalent across various target groups, including those with intellectual disabilities, and strive to promote healthier behaviours at home, in schools, and across different social environments. By adopting an age-appropriate approach, we will ensure our strategies cater to the evolving needs of children from the age of 6 and adolescents up to the age of 25, even in (early career) work environments.

Project partners: Katholieke Universiteit Leuven, Thomas More Kempen Vzw, Associazione Italiana Per L Assistenza Agli Spastici Provincia Di Bologna, Fundacion Prodis, Fundacio Privada I2cat, Internet I Innovacio Digital A Catalunya, Fundacion Socialinnolabs, Stichting VU, MetropolisFilm, Open The Windows, European Association of Service providers for Persons with Disabilities, European Scout Region, FinCons, Lorang Innovation, Universidad Politécnica de Madrid

DigiSoc Involvement: Project coordinator

TECH4WELLBEING

Related WGs: Health & Well-Being

Abstract: This project aims to improve the collaboration between the welfare sector and the technology sector to develop solutions that support children and young people (ages 5 to 25) with mild to moderate intellectual disabilities in their home environment, school environment, and leisure activities, thereby enhancing their well-being.

Our society is under pressure: performance pressure, social pressure, raising children well, all in a world that is becoming increasingly complex, demanding, and confusing. This is particularly exacerbated by constant online presence and social media. These pressures also affect our children, including those with intellectual disabilities. The combination of these (congenital) disabilities and societal pressures makes it especially difficult for our children and young people to feel "at ease" in our society, despite (or partly due to) all technological advancements.

Therefore, we see it as our duty as knowledge institutions to address this challenge and demonstrate how we can effectively use technology to support such children and help them feel more at home in our society.

Project partners: UCLL, Artevelde Hogeschool, Thomas More

DigiSoc Involvement: WP Lead Dissemination and Valorization

HARMONY

Related WGs: Health & Well-Being

Abstract: In the current labour market, persons with intellectual disabilities (ID) receive (too) little attention and are all too often not actively involved in employment promotion initiatives, mainly because this is a relatively limited group within the group of persons with a distance to the labour market. Moreover, valuable initiatives to employ persons with ID are often fragmented across the EU. Transnational cooperation is thus necessary to give this target group better access to the labour market throughout the NWE region and strengthen their social and societal integration. HARMONY will increase employment among people with ID by developing, upscaling and promoting eXtended Reality (XR) interventions and trainings to complement existing employment programmes. As several cases show that every day skills can be acquired or strongly improved by training in virtual environments, HARMONY will use the unique opportunities that XR interventions offers. HARMONY will focus on three important aspects to reach successful employment: 1) A correct and fair screening of employment skills to find the best match between employee and workplace. 2) Training specific employment and adaptive behaviour. 3) Cultivate empathy towards people with ID to enhance the working environment. HARMONY will set up a long-term platform including a comprehensive knowledge base that collects and shares scientific knowledge, best practices, relevant XR applications and training programmes across the NWE and EU region. This platform will be used to create awareness and provide easy-to use trainings that can be directly implemented in the field in each of the different member states. It also contains jointly created strategies and implementation plans adapted to the local context to facilitate organisations in becoming a more inclusive workplace.

Project partners: Thomas More Kempen vzw, KU Leuven, De Lovie, Thomas More Mechelen-Antwerp, VU Amsterdam, FINCONS Group, Association for Research and Training on Integration in Europe, University College Dublin, Catholic University of Applied Sciences KHSB, Trinity College Dublin, I-Deas: 3DNovations, SMARTlab creative technology innovation

DigiSoc involvement: Coordinating the dissemination activities

INNOVAITE

Related WGs: Digital Ethics, Technological and Societal Trends

Abstract: The rapid rise and integration of Artificial Intelligence (AI) in business and the public sector bring significant opportunities for addressing societal challenges and fostering innovation and growth within SMEs/SMBs. A report by the Social and Economic Council of Flanders (SERV, 2020) demonstrates how AI can drive innovation in various domains. In healthcare, for example, AI can be used for managing medical records and data, drug development and treatments, medication management, precision medicine, health

monitoring, system analyses in healthcare, and more. In (professional) learning and education, AI can be used to develop personalized learning processes through adaptive learning platforms or to support distance learning and hybrid teaching environments. Governments can leverage AI innovations to strengthen democracy and civic engagement. AI can improve interactions with and services to citizens, such as through interactive chatbots, offering customized services, or automatically granting certain rights. AI tools can also be integrated into experiments of e-democracy or via participation platforms where citizens can be heard and interact with governments. The report also shows how AI innovation offers numerous benefits in sectors such as mobility, logistics, the food industry, manufacturing, and more. However, the ethical and legal questions and challenges that come with this are often avoided by companies, either out of ignorance or because they are seen as obstacles to innovation. This can lead to undesirable consequences such as bias, breaches of privacy or copyright regulations, opaque decision-making, or hindrances to the implementation and realization of new AI-related applications. Through the Interreg Vlaanderen-Nederland program, we aim to address these issues by promoting transparent, ethical, and innovative AI applications by public institutions and SMEs/SMBs through cross-border collaboration among relevant actors.

Project partners: Tilburg University (Digital Sciences for Society), KU Leuven (DigiSoc), Midpointbrabant, Mindlabs, Leuven Mindgate

DigiSoc involvement: Key partner

PARTICIPARTE

Related WGs: Media & Culture, Democracy & Civic Engagement

Abstract: PARTiCIPARTE takes a Speculative Design approach to involve and guide local citizens, artists, policymakers, and educators in collaboratively exploring the potential of desirable futures through the creation of imaginative narratives to foster robust and sustainable political engagement, informed by patterns and trends derived from multimodal analysis (O'Halloran, 2021) of creative political participation in digital and metaverse spaces over the past decade. To set the scope for political engagements, PARTiCIPARTE will conduct research through three distinct use-cases, in line with the 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDG): 1) Participatory (Urban) Design (SDG#11: sustainable cities and Communities), 2) Climate Activism (SDG#7: affordable and clean energy, SDG#12: responsible consumption and production, SDG#13: climate action, SDG#14: life below water, SDG#15: life on land) and 3. Social Inclusion (SDG#3: good health and well-being, SDG#5: gender equality, SDG#10 reduced inequalities). PARTiCIPARTE brings together a unique consortium of multidisciplinary researchers in design, arts, political science, architecture and citizen participation, as well as cultural and community spaces, artists, designers, technology developers, impact strategists and socially-engaged organisations with a world-wide network. The dynamic blend of design, arts, futures perspectives, politics, and policy ensures a comprehensive and impactful approach, fostering sustainable outcomes with societal relevance. Together, we will create a lasting and positive impact on democratic behaviour.

Project partners: LUCA School of Arts, KU Leuven (DigiSoc), University of Liverpool, Forschungszentrum Informatik, Empyria Soft, Open Impact, Knowle West Media Centre, Zentrum für Kunst und Medien Karlsruhe, United Nations Educational Scientific and Cultural Organisation

DigiSoc involvement: Dissemination, Exploitation and Communication partner

AIHUMS101: ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE & HUMANITIES (101)

Related WGs: Media and Culture

Abstract: Artificial intelligence and digitalization have the potential to radically change education and careers in the Humanities. However, we still have a poor idea of what students need to know to engage in these developments. How can we prepare students to play a part in this transformation? What more can Una Europa institutions do to achieve this? AIHUMS101 will answer these questions, producing a survey on current teaching within Una Europa, a model syllabus of an introductory course to AI and the digital for Humanities students, and a toolkit to help integrate AI into existing courses. Through 2 workshops, 4 online meetings and a session with students at the Future UniLab, the project will bring together 32 academics, 7 universities and 8 institutes.

Project partners: Jagiellonian University, University of Bologna, University of Edinburgh, University College Dublin, Leiden University, Complutense University of Madrid, KU Leuven (DigiSoc)

DigiSoc involvement: Project partner

INCLUSIVE PERSPECTIVES ON ETHICAL GAME DESIGN

Related WGs: Digital Ethics, Media and Culture

Abstract: The development of video games raises numerous ethical questions. As an experiential medium, it has acutely posed the question of what content is acceptable and desirable in cultural products since its inception. In video games, players might directly experience shocking, hurtful sequences, or those that challenge the integrity of certain human groups, rather than simply being confronted with them passively. Furthermore, as a mass participatory leisure activity, it faces the excesses of certain toxic communities, which often tend to target already vulnerable or marginalized groups. More recently, the "games as a service" economic model has led to the development of aggressive, diverted, or manipulative monetization and retention strategies, sometimes reaching the level of dark patterns. Nevertheless, these potential dangers are accompanied by great promises: by placing players in decision-making and action roles during moments involving ethical principles, video games can serve as powerful tools for reflection, education, and ethical critique. Similarly, online communities have regularly proven to be spaces for discussion, acceptance, and expression for individuals seeking social support. Finally, numerous ethical design initiatives propose monetization and distribution models for video games that aim to be ethical, accessible, and sustainable.



However, the research underpinning these initiatives is marked by the same hegemonic vision they aim to critique. Thus, reflections on ethical game design take the Western experience, privileged economically and socially, as their starting point. Contrarily, research rooted in different contexts lacks resonance and a space to connect in a global approach.

By bringing together researchers from all continents, representing the full diversity of ethical conceptions in video games, and adopting a perspective of critique of knowledge and design, this project will contribute to structuring inclusive and pluralistic perspectives on ethics in video game development. To this end, our project will follow a step-by-step approach to, first, coordinate the exchange of rich, yet local analyses and actions around ethics in game design, by taking into account the diverse sensitivities and perspectives on the matter. Second, it will foster interdisciplinary, multinational, multi-methods comparisons for a both holistic and critical view on ethics. Third, it will address the need for comprehensive decisions and frameworks around ethics that suit the international and globalized video game production context. Last but not least, it will build a worldwide consortium with diversified expertise for future state-of-the art research and development on ethical game design.

Project partners (to be completed): Ethical Games Conference, FairPlayAlliance, Fordham University, KU Leuven (DigiSoc)

DigiSoc involvement: Project coordinator

Events

All our DigiSoc members regularly present their work at various conferences or events. In our bi-monthly newsletters, we highlight some of these presentations when relevant for the broader DigiSoc community.

In the overview below, we list those events where either DigiSoc's research manager represented DigiSoc, or where DigiSoc explicitly supported the event, e.g. by communicating the event through its networks.

EBEN CONFERENCE & MONT BLANC CIRCLE

On 2 February 2024, DigiSoc Research Manager **Dr. David Geerts** gave a presentation on "A Human-Centered Approach to Ethical AI" at an event of the European Business Ethics Network (EBEN) with the theme "Ethics in AI" (see Figure 4).

As a result of the latter event, Dr. David Geerts was invited to give the same presentation for the Mont Blanc Circle of Compliance Officers on 17 May 2024.



Figure 4: Program of the EBEN conference on Ethics in AI, featuring DigiSoc's research manager as one of the keynote speakers.

INTEROPERABILITY EUROPE ACADEMY (IOEUP)

The Interoperable Europe Academy, co-organized by DigiSoc member prof. **Joep Crompvoets**, took place in Leuven on 11 and 12 April 2024. This event, co-organised by the European Commission and the University

of KU Leuven, with the support of DigiSoc, was a unique opportunity for public servants, policymakers, and students to deepen their understanding of the Interoperable Europe Act and public sector interoperability in general. Offering a mix of workshops and panel discussions with experts, the Academy was designed to **enhance skills in digital government and interoperability**. Participants had the chance to explore the latest developments in artificial intelligence (AI), data spaces, EUDI Wallet, Digital Single Gateway and much more.



Figure 5: Introduction session of the IOEUP Academy.

WOMEN & AI

On Monday 18 March, DigiSoc director prof. **Bieke Zaman**, along with DigiSoc members prof. **Marie-Francine Moens** and prof. **Tinne De Laet**, participated in a panel on Women in AI, organized by Lean In Leuven Law (including DigiSoc member **Victoria Hendrickx**), and supported by KU Leuven Digital Society Institute and Leuven.AI.

In prof. Zaman's panel contribution (see Figure 4), she shed light on the overlooked but vital **contributions of women in shaping the history of technology**, tracing back to the post-WWII era when "computer" referred to a person's job, predominantly held by women. These trailblazers not only performed complex calculations manually but also laid the groundwork for electronic computing. Yet, why has this history been forgotten, and where do women stand in the tech landscape today? Has much changed? Prof. Zaman explored these questions by illuminating the intricate relationship between societal (f)actors and technological progress. She addressed broader issues such as the disproportionate low representation of non-men in tech-related education, research, workforce, and venture capital funding. Furthermore, she discussed how technology, including AI, is often developed from the perspective of a specific demographic – typically young, native English-speaking men from privileged backgrounds.



Figure 6: DigiSoc Director prof. Bieke Zaman presenting her panel contribution.

DAG VAN DE ONDERWIJSONDERSTEUNER

On 26 April 2024, KU Leuven organized a day for educational support personnel. At the closing panel, DigiSoc's research manager Dr. **David Geerts** discussed the ethical aspects of generative AI.



Figure 7: DigiSoc Research Manager Dr. David Geerts on the panel on generative AI.

KEYNOTE FOR THE PLATTELANDSACADEMIE

DigiSoc's research manager Dr. **David Geerts** gave a presentation about human-centered digitalisation for an inclusive digital society at the 'Plattelandsacademie' on 27 April 2024 (see Figure 5). The participants were members of local governments in Flanders, mostly of rural municipalities.



Figure 8: DigiSoc Research Manager presenting at the Plattelandsacademie.

Communication

WEBSITE

From May 2023 until April 2024, the period of this annual report, the DigiSoc website received almost 2000 visitors, which is a 50% increase over the same period the year before. See Figure 9 for a detailed overview of website visitors over the whole year.

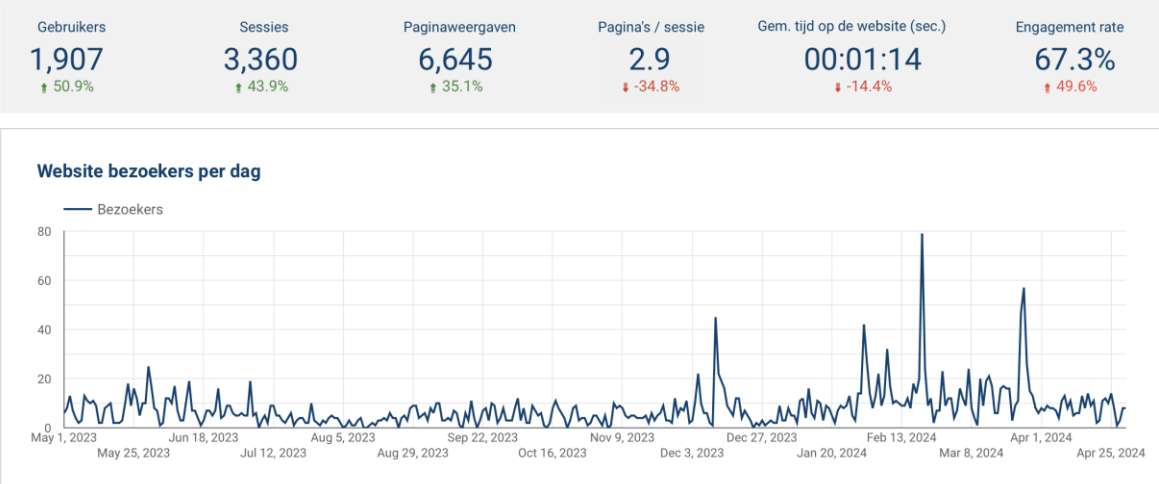


Figure 9: DigiSoc website visitors per day (May 2023-April 2024).

Of the 2000 visitors, half are returning visitors, while 44,4% are new (see Figure 10).

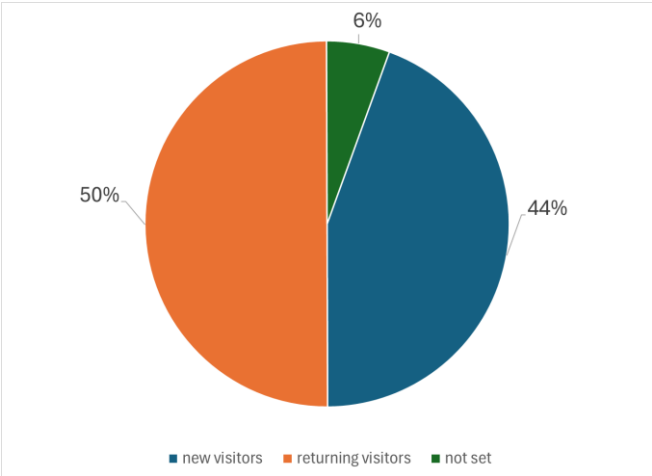


Figure 10: New (44,4%) vs. returning visitors (50%) on the DigiSoc website (5,4 % not yet set).

The most visited pages of the DigiSoc website are the homepage, the page with information about the Hybrid Course on Digital Ethics, the members page and the about page.

Page Title	Page address	Views
KU Leuven Digital Society Institute - Main	/digisoc	1427
Hybrid Course on Digital Ethics	/digisoc/education-and-training/hybrid-course-on-digital-ethics	1009
DigiSoc members	/digisoc/members	713
Research	/digisoc/research/research	273
Education and Training	/digisoc/education-and-training/educationandtraining	182
Collaborate with DigiSoc	/digisoc/collaborate	148
Research	/digisoc/research	130
Events	/digisoc/events	127
Domains	/digisoc/domains/index.html	123
DigiSoc Whitepaper	/digisoc/about/digisoc-whitepaper	111

Figure 11: Most visited pages on the DigiSoc website (May 2023-April 2024).

NEWSLETTERS

DigiSoc sends out a **bimonthly newsletter** in order to showcase some of the work that is being done by the various members of our institute. The first newsletter was sent in October 2021, and in total 17 newsletters have been sent out to date (see https://www.kuleuven.be/digisoc/news/previous-digisoc-newsletters).

Currently, there are 429 people subscribed to the newsletter (+19% compared to last year), both from KU Leuven and external organizations.

SOCIAL MEDIA: LEAVING X

DigiSoc has a **presence on social media** to ensure a wide reach of its communication activities, and is mainly active on LinkedIn (https://www.linkedin.com/company/ku-leuven-digital-society-institute/) and recently also more on Mastodon (handle: @KULeuvenDigiSoc@mastodon.online).

Our LinkedIn Page has 489 followers (+96% compared to last year).

Our Mastodon account has 36 followers (+39% compared to last year) and has sent out 21 posts so far. We aim to increase our activity on Mastodon, as explained in the following paragraph.

On our General Assembly of 13 June 2024, we announced that we would **close our X account**. This was the result of an initiative of one of our members drawing attention on the fact that X has taken a toxic and unethical turn recently. As these are not values that DigiSoc endorses, we decided to turn to 'fediverse' alternatives instead of closed and centralized BigTech platforms, in order to more genuinely act in alignment with our mission and values. As a speaker at our 2021 DigiSoc launch event, prof. José van Dijck already spoke about these themes: the undemocratic power of BigTech companies. It also ties in with arguments in our 2023 white paper on data governance and civic empowerment. Such a decision and reasoning also resonates with the motivation why several other institutions in for instance the Netherlands and Germany have decided to leave X and become more active on the 'fediverse' (see e.g. https://www.surf.nl/mastodon-pilot-voor-onderzoek-en-onderwijs).

The Executive Committee closed our X account on 9 July 2024. In parallel, it was also decided to intensify our communication and engagement activities via Mastodon.

By the end of 2024, we aim to organize a university-wide discussion with Ethics@KU Leuven on the presence of KU Leuven and other universities on X and other BigTech platforms.

At the time of closure, our X account had 530 followers (+25% compared to last year) and had sent out 129 tweets in total.

First Term Evaluation

PROCEDURE

Each new KU Leuven Institute is **formally assessed after four years of existence**, to decide if its recognition will be renewed for four additional years. The general purpose of the evaluation, which is primarily qualitative, but incorporates quantitative KPIs as well, is to focus on the added value created by the institute, the new opportunities it made possible, and the synergies it initiated. This assessment is conducted by the Research Coordination office, and takes place within a series of evaluations during the institute's lifecycle: before its accreditation, at mid-term, and at the end of its first term. This way, part of each evaluation is dedicated to assessing how the feedback from the previous evaluation was implemented.

In **preparation of the assessment**, the Research Coordination Office provides each institute with data from a network analysis which highlights publications and acquired projects based on interdisciplinary collaborations between the institute's members. This outcome then helps the institutes draft their own dossier, which is submitted to the Commission KU Leuven Institutes. Each dossier is evaluated by an international panel composed of a president, and of panel members selected based on the focus of each institute (one panel member per institute). Together with the Research Coordination Office, the panel member relevant for a given institute selects 3 ad-hoc referees to provide an opinion on the dossier. Subsequently, the Directors of the institute present their dossier in an interview with the panel. After this, the panel submits a proposal of extension or otherwise to the Executive Board and Academic Council of KU Leuven, which take the final decision.

CONTENT OF THE EVALUATION DOSSIER

As DigiSoc exists since 1 May 2021, our first four-year term is coming closer and foreseen in May 2025. As mentioned in the previous yearly report, our mid-term evaluation was very positive. We can thus confidently look at the future and **define a strategy for the next four years**. Within the dossier that we will submit, this strategy must explain any new accents, shifts, or changes in approach compared to the initial policy plan. Advice from the **External Advisory Board** is also taken into account.

Next to this policy plan, the dossier should contain a report discussing:

- the realisation of DigiSoc's objectives and mission as set up at the start of the accreditation and revised for the mid-term.
- the actual operation of the governance structure
- the updated financial plan for the past period and the budget preparation for the next period, with an explanation of the progress made to become self-sustaining
- the evolution of the research lines, and the DigiSoc's contribution to quality and ambition in research
- new KU Leuven-internal synergies within and across disciplines, as well as new external collaborations with academic and non-academic groups

- actions for the publicity and visibility of the institute
- activities or initiatives showing that the DigiSoc is considered a point of reference within its topics
- the achievement of societal impact

COMING STEPS

To prepare for this evaluation in the best possible way, a bottom-up path has been defined.

First, during our General Assembly (GA) of 13 June 2024, we solicited feedback from our members on how to shape our future plans. Members suggested identifying more precisely which stakeholders DigiSoc wants to reach, for instance via a stakeholder management plan. To strengthen DigiSoc's lead position in interdisciplinary, digital topics, it was recommended to communicate about the institute at conferences addressing these themes, and to make DigiSoc's contribution more visible in presentations at public events, for example by using a disclaimer for presentations resulting from DigiSoc collaborations. In general, GA members called for the definition of a strategy that establishes DigiSoc as a key player in all relevant areas, with the research manager as the central point of contact for organizations and individuals interested in collaborations.

In a second phase, the Executive Committee will process this input during a Strategy meeting towards strategic directions and proposals for action. This strategy will be presented at the External Advisory Board meeting (26 August), so that the EAB can also provide feedback.

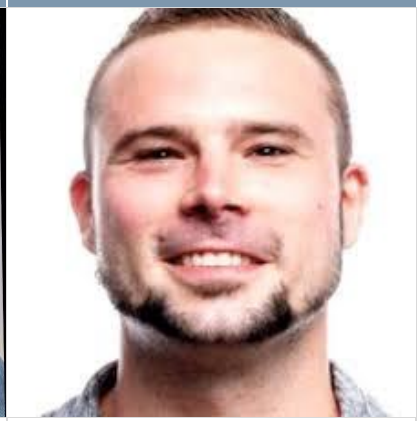
On this basis, we will set up a draft report that will be discussed during the next General Assembly meeting in November 2024. In the meantime, the Research Coordination Office will update the evaluation calendar, so that we know the exact dates for the next steps. These include updating the publications and projects issued from collaborations within DigiSoc to ensure that the network analysis bases on accurate data, and setting an agenda for finalizing our policy plan and report. We will keep you informed about this process.

We already thank you for your inspiring input so far, and hope to pursue the DigiSoc adventure with you in the next term!

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DIGISOC MEMBERS

See https://www.kuleuven.be/digisoc/members